



No horsin' around in this new tower defense mobile game.

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Disclaimer: the last competitive tower defense game I really enjoyed playing was Sanctum 2 on the PC. Or maybe one of the Orcs Must Die! games. Be as it may, KRAFTON's mobile games haven't been disappointing, in any way, so when we got the beta codes for Defense Derby, I jumped into it quite quickly.

The game incorporates some interesting elements from other mobile games and does a great job putting it all together. Spoiler alert: Despite being called Defense 'Derby', the game has no connection to horses. This might be important to some people. Possibly.

That said, the game does have a bit of a learning curve, which people may or may not find somewhat frustrating. Personally, I found the challenge refreshing. Although, if I'm nitpicking, I would've liked to have a training ground, of sorts. An offline PvE arena where you can see your builds in action before taking on real players.

The Basics

Defense Derby's arena (aka, Derby) comprises a 3x3 grid of units, with a hero in the middle of the cube. You and three others face the same waves of enemies. Each player starts with two units (plus the hero) from their deck, and after each wave of enemies that you beat (or survive), you either get a random unit from your own loadout, or bid on a random unit from any of the four players' decks to fill your arena.

The bidding system requires some strategy and foresight on the players' part. Outbidding or underbidding gives players a chance to get ahead, or push their rivals out of their derbies. The units are categorised in three factions: Human, Beast, and Spirit; each dealing one of two types of damage: Physical or Magical. Lining up your units to match either faction or dam-



age type gives bonus stats to each unit. This is something players need to keep in mind not only when creating their own loadout, but also when bidding for units. I've seen it make a crucial difference when winning and losing games.

The units and heroes in the game can also be upgraded (Common to Mythic) or levelled up to improve stats like attack speed, damage and buffs/debuffs. So... Just another two things to keep in mind.

Your loadout consists of one hero, eight units and three artifacts. Five artifacts are dropped every day by completing your daily quests, and can be upgraded with multiple drops of the same artifact. These give specific buffs to your loadout, and can be swapped out in your loadout based on your playstyle.